



The movie's original Swedish poster shows death waiting impassively at the bottom, with the human characters on the black squares of a chessboard.

“Feel, to the very end, the triumph of being alive!”

Squire Jöns / The Seventh Seal

The knight searches, but he finds nothing. At one point he happens upon a girl (Maud Hansson) imprisoned in a cage, who is about to be burned at the stake. She is accused of sleeping with the Devil and bringing the plague upon the people. Antonius is hopeful: if the Devil exists, then so must God. “Look in my eyes,” the girl says, as she tells him that the priest would not come near her. “I see nothing but terror,” the knight replies, sadly. The girl is burned, and

the knight’s squire, Jöns (Gunnar Björnstrand), can see no meaning in her murder. “Look into her eyes,” he echoes. “She sees nothing but

emptiness.” The squire is scornful of people’s fears and the ignorance that leads them to burn the witch.

Self-flagellation

If all of this sounds somewhat earnest, that’s because it is. *The Seventh Seal* is concerned with the soul and damnation; with man’s masochistic relationship with his Creator; and with the howling wilderness that awaits each of us at the end of the road. Bergman communicates his vast ideas in the simplest and most striking of images. In one extraordinary sequence, a group of self-flagellating monks lurches past the camera, some staggering under the heavy weight of crosses, others whipping themselves. The plague, which they believe to be a punishment from God, has driven them insane. Bergman cuts to the faces of Jof and Mia as they watch

